POEM: OZYMANDIAS

Ozymandias

I met a traveller from an antique land

Who said: "Two vast and trunkless legs of stone

Stand in the desert. Near them, on the sand,

Half sunk, a shattered visage lies, whose frown,

And wrinkled lip, and sneer of cold command,

Tell that its sculptor well those passions read

Which yet survive, stamped on these lifeless things,

The hand that mocked them and the heart that fed:

And on the pedestal these words appear:

'My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:

Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!'

Nothing beside remains. Round the decay

Of that colossal wreck, boundless and bare

The lone and level sands stretch far away."

Percy Bysshe Shelly

Antique suggests the place is old and steeped in history, but also it may be out of date and old fashioned.

*The statue is barely standing, the rest is ruined and missing. Suggesting that it is being eaten away by time and the desert, a **futile** struggle to survive where nobody is around to care.*

*Shattered visage-: Broken face, it is **unrecognisable**, a statue to someone and we can no longer tell who, has no purpose anymore.*

*Cold command, sneer: suggests Ozymandias' character as powerful and arrogant ironic now there is nothing left. **Synaesthesia.***

*'Mock' as in to make a model of, but also to make fun of, this is a **Pun** because of the double meaning.*

*The **tone,** indicated by the **exclamation** is strong and authoritative, irony is that nobody is listening.*

*Colossal, meaning vast or huge, is a **metaphor** for his ego rather than the statue.*

*The lone and level sands outlast the statue, **juxtaposed** to the power and ego of the statue.*

*Sands are also **iconic** of time.*

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look up more information about Ozymandias and the statue of Ramesses II.

-Read the poem aloud and consider the different tones in the poem.

Context:

Written by Shelly in a collection in 1819, it was inspired by the recent unearthing of part of a large statue of the Egyptian Pharoah, Ramesses II. The Egyptian Pharaohs like Ramesses believed themselves to be gods in mortal form and that their legacy would last forever. The reference to the stone statue is likely a direct reference to the statues and sculptures like the one which was unearthed, which the ancient Egyptians made.

On the base of the statue is written (translated) "*King of Kings am I, Osymandias. If anyone would know how great I am and where I lie, let him surpass one of my works.*"

The Statue of Ramesses which now sits in the London Museum

Themes:

Looking at power and conflict we can imagine Ozymandias as a powerful ruler who sees himself as a 'king of kings', perhaps a great warrior and one of the most powerful men in the world.

The poem is almost being ironic, pointing out that now all that remains is an arrogant boast on a ruined statue. Perhaps the poet feels sorry for him or is laughing at his expense. Either way it looks about the inevitable downfall of all rulers and tyrants, and how nothing, not even power, lasts forever.

Allegory:

The statue in the poem, broken and falling apart in the desert with nobody to care is an allegory of Ozymandias and of every powerful man or woman, the idea that they will also drift away until they are just another grain of sand.

Structure: Written in a **sonnet** with loose iambic pentameter. **Iambic pentameter** is pairs (iams, of sounds *da-dum)* with 5 (pentameter, think of pent like in pentagon) in a line making 10 syllables overall.

Sonnets were generally popular romantic or love poems, perhaps this being a love poem about Ozymandias, a joke about the rulers ego. Or simply to capture the romantic and exotic tone of a lost legend.

The Rhyme scheme is irregular, perhaps symbolic of the broken statue itself, no longer perfect.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem is a ironic memorial to the ego of a ancient Pharaoh *-The statue is an allegory for the eventual end of power that everyone must suffer, especially the proud* *-Power, like the statue is lost to the sands which in turn represent time*	*-The poem is about the statue of a long dead king* *-The statue is breaking down, this shows how people are forgetting the dead king* *-Power does not last forever*

Space for your notes: